

PICKING BUDS Congress's Rahul Gandhi meets tribal women gathering mahua in the forests of Umaria, MP

wooing—under the ST umbrella, has also ruffled feathers in the state. Similarly, in Gujarat, the ST status granted to the pastoral Maldhari community of the Gir forests (in 2021) has activated a fault line.

Implementation of the Forests Rights Act is an issue in western and eastern Madhya Pradesh as well as in many other tribal areas in the country. "Successive governments have denied claims, hence the migration in search of jobs," says Venkat Ramanujam Ramani, postdoctoral research associate at the Ashoka Trust for Research in Ecology and the Environment (ATREE). "Fragmentation of land and lack of availability for water for irrigation are also issues affecting tribals." The notification of the PESA (Panchayats Extension to Scheduled Areas) Rules, which protect tribal gram sabhas in MP and Chhattisgarh, in 2021 is seen as too little too late.

EDUCATION LEVELS AMONG TRIBAL COMMUNITIES MAY BE UP, BUT FINDING WHITE-COLLAR JOBS IS DIFFICULT. MANY HAVE RETURNED TO FARMING

Chhotu Vasava, a tribal strongman in Bharuch, Gujarat, says tribals have always been dealt a raw deal under all governments. "The gram panchayats have the primacy of power in deciding on village land usage, but they are constantly undermined. What is the point of a Sardar Patel statue (the 182-metre Statue of Unity) when what we really needed was an Adivasi *sarovar* that would have been a source of irrigation for us?" asks the Bharat Tribal Party (BTP) founder.

The Saffron Counter

On November 15, 2023, Bhagchand Adivasi, a Sahariya tribal from MP's Shivpuri village, became the lucky owner of a 'pucca house', handed over to him remotely by the prime minister himself. Built under the Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTG) mission, it's part of the flagship Rs 24,000 crore PM Janjati Adivasi Nyaya Maha Abhiyan (PM-Janman), the big showpiece in the Modi government's plan to woo the tribal voter.

Launched on the same day—the newly created 'Janjatiya Gaurav Divas' commemorating tribal hero Birsa Munda's birth anniversary—PM-Janman has identified 75 tribal communities in some 22,000 villages across the country who will be the focus of the PVTG mission. According to a PMO note, this will consist of '11 critical interventions spread through nine line ministries and covering 18 states and a UT'. One of these key 'interventions' will be the construction of 490,000 houses for tribals, at a cost of Rs 2.39 lakh each.

Another key area of central government focus is improving education levels in the tribal areas, both through the state's Eklavya schools and the VKA-run institutions. The number of Eklavya Model Residential Schools (EMRS) has gone up to some 700 now, from 119 in 2013-14, and has become a key poll plank for the party. A tribal affairs ministry reply in the Rajya Sabha in 2023 said that literacy rates in the backward communities is 72 per cent. As much as there is to cheer here, there is a downside too—white-collar jobs are harder to come by. Vijay Singh Chopda of the Jai Adivasi Yuva Shakti, an organisation based in Dhar, MP, says, "Rising awareness and education levels have led to aspirations for